

The Witherspoon Institute

Thomistic Seminar

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Common Happiness

Morning Session

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Readings:

Aquinas and the Ethics of Happiness, *Ch. 6*

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From Individual Happiness to Common Happiness

Grasping the heart of Aquinas's account of individual happiness is the starting point for understanding how Aquinas unifies his ethical system around happiness. The second step is understanding the relationship between individual happiness and common happiness – in other words, the happiness of some relevant “complete community” (i.e., a community that has a sufficient supply of “whatever is necessary for life” for its inhabitants, something that Aquinas thinks will typically be the case in a single city, although such a city may also be a part of a larger province or state).¹ This step is crucial because, as I read Aquinas, it is *common happiness* that is the true ultimate end of human beings (this chapter); it is *common happiness* that forms a crucial part of the essence of law (Chapter 7); and a character trait is a virtue of character fundamentally because it enables a person to play their part in realizing *common happiness* (Chapter 8).

This chapter sets out the contours of that common happiness. I argue that, as Aquinas thinks of it, common happiness is a *common* or *shared* activity that involves two deeply interrelated aspects. The first is the individual happinesses – that is, the genuinely good enjoyed activities – of those who make up the relevant complete community. The second is the profound sort of justice, peace, and well-coordinated action that exists among those individuals in that relevant community; this captures at least the minimal sense in which they are all engaged in a common or shared activity. After showing that this is, indeed, how Aquinas understands the nature of common happiness, I then argue that Aquinas is committed to the idea that the true ultimate end of each human being is the very best sort of common happiness. In particular, the true ultimate end of each human being is the *fruitio* of God that is *common* or *shared* with God and

¹ InPOL lib.1 l.1 n.23. See also, e.g., DR lib.1 cap.2 co. On the notion of a complete community, see, e.g., Finnis (1998a), 219–222, and Dewan (2007), 297–300.

all those in heaven. That is the first element of Aquinas's Holistic Eudaimonism.

However, before turning to the case for thinking of common happiness in this way or the case for treating the common happiness of heaven as the true ultimate end of human beings, it is important to address a natural question about the importance that I am ascribing to common happiness within Aquinas's ethical project: If it is so crucial, why does he so seldom explicitly mention it and never offer a sustained treatment of its nature?

6.1 Uncovering Common Happiness

It is certainly true that Aquinas seldom explicitly mentions common happiness by name and also certainly true that he never treats it in a sustained fashion.² However, it seems to me that it is hiding in plain sight. In particular, it seems that common happiness just is the most important sense of 'common good' (*bonum commune*), as related to human communities. This comes through at a crucial moment in the *Summa theologiae*, namely, in Aquinas's definition of law.

In building up to that well-known definition, Aquinas asks whether a genuine law is always ultimately ordered to the common good of a whole community or whether it is possible for a genuine law to be ordered ultimately to the good of some single person or to the good of some subset of members of a community.³ He answers that a genuine law is always ordered to the common good.⁴ Now, in his explanation he makes it clear that, in the context of law's essence, law's being ordered "to the common good" (*ad bonum commune*) is equivalent to its being ordered "to common happiness" (*ad felicitatem communem*).⁵ This is clear because Aquinas moves without comment from slowly building to and then further supporting his conclusion that "it is necessary properly that law look to the order to common happiness" to the article's conclusion that "every law is ordered to the common good."⁶ There is no indication that Aquinas intends to distinguish between "common happiness" and "the common

² By my count, there are only six occurrences in the corpus (in whatever declension), only three of which seem relevant to the sense of the term that I am interested in.

³ ST IaIIae q.90 a.2. On historical antecedents to Aquinas's account of the common good, see, e.g., Lottin (1948) and Porter (2005b), 97–106. For a discussion of the common good in late medieval political thought generally, see Kempshall (1999).

⁴ According to Porter (2005b), 109, this is the first time in the Scholastic tradition that all genuine law was explicitly linked to the common good. It does seem, however, that Albert the Great proposed some sort of link in this vein (see Kempshall (1999), 112).

⁵ ST IaIIae q.90 a.2 co. ⁶ ST IaIIae q.90 a.2 co.

good” in this context and no textual reason to deny the identification.⁷ So it seems that when Aquinas is talking about the common good of a community, unless there is special reason to think he has a different sense of ‘common good’ in mind, he is thereby talking about the *common happiness* of a community.⁸ And since Aquinas has a fair amount to say about the common good of a community, we can use those references to help us better understand his account of common happiness.

Even if one is convinced by this extremely brief line of thought (or by the longer discussion in Chapter 7), one might still wonder whether we should treat common happiness as central to Aquinas’s ethical project. After all, just like there is no treatise on common happiness, there’s no treatise on the common good either.⁹ There are frequent remarks about the common good, but they are scattered throughout his corpus. One might think that this tells against the idea that the common good or common happiness is central to what Aquinas is up to.

However, the common good or the common happiness of a community does important work in a string of absolutely critical places in Aquinas’s ethics, as we’ll see in great detail in the chapters that follow and as we’ve just briefly seen in the case of law’s very essence. As a result, it is hard to treat these notions as anything but central, despite the piecemeal accounts of them that Aquinas gives. Perhaps one reason that Aquinas didn’t feel the need to focus a sustained discussion on them has to do with the fact that these notions are, by necessity, extremely general or formal in nature. They include little particular content about how a community should be organized or behave. If I am right, common happiness is a matter of justice, peace, well-coordinated action, and the individual happinesses of a community’s members. Having connected all of these ideas to common

⁷ In the secondary literature, the main reaction to Aquinas’s moving from talk of “common happiness” to “the common good” has been to ignore it. Some people don’t mention this fact at all, even in sustained discussions of Aquinas’s account of law – see, e.g., DeYoung, McCluskey, and Van Dyke (2009), chapter 8, and Irwin (2007), 545–570. Some mention it but continue on as if there is nothing substantive to be learned from this fact – see, e.g., Brock (2010), 236–237; Kossel (2002), 170–171; and Copleston (1962), 137. Roniger (2020), 283, treats common happiness as very important but does so mostly in passing. The only person of whom I am aware who treats this identification as vitally important in a sustained way is Goyette (2013), 134. I understand the impulse to ignore this shift. It is remarkable how infrequently Aquinas uses the term ‘common happiness’ (*felicitas communis* or *beatitudo communis*).

⁸ Some interpreters think that Aquinas doesn’t distinguish between *the* common good and common goods (see, e.g., Brock (2010), 234, fn.1). I think that *the* common good is equivalent to common happiness, whereas the other things called “common goods” are ordered in some way or other to *the* common good (i.e., common happiness). For a helpful discussion of the senses of ‘common good’ in Aquinas, see Froelich (1989). See also Kempshall (1999), chapter 3.

⁹ Noted, e.g., by Froelich (1989), 38, and Porter (2005b), 96.

happiness or the common good of a community in various works, perhaps Aquinas thought that what his readers needed was precisely what he gave: extended treatments on justice, peace, how to coordinate a community, and the nature of individual happiness.

6.2 The Nature of Common Happiness

When one hears “common happiness,” it would be natural to suppose that this is meant in a figurative way and not meant to pick out a genuine kind of happiness at all. After all, one might think *communities* can’t be happy, only *people* can. One might suppose instead that what is meant is that a community can be described figuratively as happy or as enjoying common happiness when it contains enough happy individuals. In other words, one might think that common happiness is simply a matter of aggregating happy people.

I do not believe that, for Aquinas, common happiness is meant figuratively, nor is it simply a matter of aggregating happy people. As I read him, common happiness is a genuine kind of happiness that is exclusively an activity with the right characteristics. It is a *common* or *shared* activity, or an activity – in some sense – done with others. More precisely, common happiness is constituted by all (or very many) of a community’s members engaging in and enjoying genuinely good activities that are consistent with, partially constitutive of, and motivated at some level by the individual happinesses of a community’s members as well as justice, peace, and well-coordinated community action. This is no mere collection of happy individuals because they share at least key fundamental aims whenever they act: They want, at a minimum, to protect and promote the happiness of those in the community as well as protect and promote justice, peace, and well-coordinated action in the community.¹⁰ At that level of generality, at least, they are all engaged in the very same shared activity, and it is that shared activity that constitutes the community’s common happiness. It is *common* because it is appropriately shared and it is *happiness* because it is a genuinely good and enjoyed activity.¹¹

¹⁰ On Aquinas’s account of coordinated activity, see, e.g., Finnis (1998a), 35–37. I agree, e.g., with Keys (2008), who emphasizes that the political community is understood by Aquinas “most fundamentally as an association whose unity comes from human action and interaction, and from common action with a view to a common end or ends” (85).

¹¹ If Aquinas held the view that all common goods are goods that can be shared without diminishing (a view sometimes ascribed to him; see, e.g., Goyette (2013), 137), then common happiness as I’ve described it would count as a common good. After all, an individual can enjoy justice, peace, well-

The overarching case for thinking of common happiness in this way is threefold. The first part is connected to Part I of this study. As should now be clear, Aquinas holds that *individual happiness* is exclusively a matter of engaging in the right sort of activity. Unless there is good reason to deny it, there should be a presumption in favor of treating *common happiness* along similar lines. This presumption is lent still greater weight because it is clear that individual happiness is a crucial part of the nature of common happiness as Aquinas understands it. After all, Aquinas insists that “the common happiness of a community” is only possible if the members of that community are happy.¹² As he goes on to explain, “It is impossible for a whole community to be happy unless all or very many parts of the community have happiness.”¹³ There is no common happiness, then, without all or very many community members’ individual happinesses – that is, without all or very many community members engaging in and enjoying genuinely good activities.¹⁴ As a result, people in a community engaging in and enjoying genuinely good activities has to be a crucial part of the nature of common happiness.

The second part of the case for thinking that common happiness is a special sort of shared activity comes from what we have good reason to believe are by Aquinas’s lights the two best models of common happiness. The first and apparently perfect model is the heavenly community or the Kingdom of Heaven, which is “the ordered society of those who enjoy the divine vision in which true happiness consists.”¹⁵ There is good reason to believe the community of heaven is the very best possible exemplar of common happiness inasmuch as, entirely generally, heaven involves the

coordinated action, and the happiness of others without diminishing those things. That said, Aquinas doesn’t think that *all* common goods can be shared without diminishing, since at least some common goods (*bonis communibus*) – such as public monies – are “distributed to individuals” and in being given to individuals they are no longer held in common (ST IIaIIae q.61 a.1 ad 2). See Froelich (1989), 53–55.

¹² InPOL lib. 2 l. 5 n.15. ¹³ InPOL lib. 2 l. 5 n.15.

¹⁴ There is other evidence for this additive element of common happiness or the common good. For example, Aquinas believes that the fact that the goods of more individuals are taken into account is reason enough to affirm that a form of government is closer to pursuing the common good (see DR lib.1, cap.4); and he says that “although the common good is more divine, nevertheless a singular good is prior in the way of generation” (InSENT lib.4 d.2 q.1 a.3 ad 3), which suggests that the common good is in some sense composed of singular goods or the goods of particular individuals. On individual happiness being a constitutive part of the common good, I agree, e.g., with Porter (1990), chapter 5, and (2005b), 113; Newman (1954), 38; Farrell (2018), 523; and Crofts (1973), 158–159. Finnis (1998a), 112–113, makes this point about common *happiness* in particular.

¹⁵ SCG lib.4 c.50 n.10. Sherwin (1993) also offers heaven as a model for thinking about the common good.

very best type of communal life possible for creatures like us. The second model is the fellowship of true friends. There is good reason to believe this is a valuable model for understanding common happiness inasmuch as Aquinas suggests a connection between common happiness and friendship by treating both as the ultimate aim of law.¹⁶ As we will see momentarily, both of these models involve what I take to be the two deeply interrelated aspects of common happiness.¹⁷ The first aspect, which I just briefly defended, is the individual happinesses of those who make up the relevant complete community. The second, to which I turn in detail below, is the profound sort of justice, peace, and well-coordinated action that exists among those individuals in that community.

The Kingdom of Heaven, with God at its head, perfectly exemplifies common happiness so understood.¹⁸ As should be familiar from Chapter 3, the heavenly community is one in which every single individual is perfectly happy; each individual is engaged in and enjoying the very best possible activity. It is also a well-ordered community in which everyone gets precisely what they are due and so justice is perfectly preserved.¹⁹ It is a community in which everyone is internally integrated, in which everyone is entirely content with what they have, in which everyone loves the other as themselves and so rejoices in the good of the other as in their own good.²⁰ In other words, as we will see, it is a community that fully enjoys true peace. And it is a community in which everyone is engaged in a shared, well-coordinated activity – not only at the level of their fundamental aims but also at the level of what they're actually doing, namely, sharing together in the *fruitio* of God.²¹ In the end, the community of heaven

¹⁶ Common happiness as ultimate aim of law: ST IaIIae q.90 a.2 co. Friendship as ultimate aim of law: ST IaIIae q.99 a.1 ad 2.

¹⁷ Cf. The well-known controversy between De Koninck and Maritain, regarding the relationship between the good of individuals and the common good; see, in particular, De Koninck (1943) and Maritain (1947a). I take it that what I say in this chapter and Chapter 8 adds support to the case for believing in the primacy of the common good, as Aquinas understands these matters. For a helpful summary of the debate, see Keys (1995). See also, e.g., Osborne (2005).

¹⁸ See, e.g., InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.1 a.2 qc.5 co. and SCG lib.4 cap.50 n.10 Cf. ST IaIIae q.91 a.5 co. God as head, see, e.g., ST IaIIae q.107 a.1 co. (Cf. De Koninck (1943).)

¹⁹ See, e.g., ST IaIIae q.26 a.7 co.; ST IaIIae q.108 a.1 ad 1; and InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.1 a.4 qc.2 ad 3.

²⁰ For internally integrated, see, e.g., ST IaIIae q.4 a.4 co. and Aquinas's various claims about the sort of virtue we enjoy in heaven (e.g., at InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.4 a.5 qc.1 co.; ST IaIIae q.61 a.5; and ST IaIIae q.67 a.2). See also the claim that the Kingdom of God involves interior peace at ST IaIIae a.108 a.1 ad 1. For contented, see, e.g., ST IaIIae q.5 a.8 ad 3. For loving others and rejoicing in their good, see, e.g., InSA a.12.

²¹ See, e.g., ST IaIIae q.4 a.8 co.; InEPH c.4 l.1; and SCG lib.4 c.50 n.10. De Koninck (1943) draws attention to the fact that perfect happiness involves this sort of shared vision of God, Who is the greatest possible Common Good *qua* object.

enjoys common happiness because every member of that community is sharing in and maximally enjoying the very best possible activity for human beings and they are doing so in a manner consistent with and partially constitutive of that community's being a just, peaceful, and well-coordinated place. As with perfect individual happiness, then, it is in heaven and heaven alone that perfect common happiness can be realized and so it is to heaven that we must look to understand the exemplar case.

The related but more familiar model of true friendship lends further support to the idea that common happiness is a matter of sharing the right sorts of activities with others.²² True friendship involves precisely the same features as common happiness as I have described it, although not on the same scale. Those acting as true friends do not treat one another unjustly.²³ True friends enjoy some measure of true peace, since – according to Aquinas, following Aristotle – true friendship requires virtue, which issues in the requisite sort of internal integration and general satisfaction (at least in suitable circumstances) that, as we will see, characterizes those living in peace.²⁴ True friends also share central goals and desires, since “it belongs to friends to will and to will against the same things” in important matters.²⁵ A true friend also desires the other's good for their own sake just as they desire their own good for their own sake, and so each enjoys the other's good as they do their own; they, of course, especially desire the other's happiness.²⁶ True friends also engage in shared and coordinated activities.²⁷ Finally, barring the sorts of impediments I noted in Chapter 4, true friends will be happy, since at least ordinarily they will engage in and enjoy genuinely good activities, animated by their

²² Froelich (1993), 619, suggests that friendship is *a* common good and the one that “best fits the description of an ultimate reason for human action.” And Finnis (1998a), 116, suggests that friendship involves being directed to a common good constituted at least in part by the well-being of each friend. What I suggest here, although different, is a kindred thought.

²³ See, e.g., InIO cap.13 l.7 and ST IIaIIae q.106 a.5 co. For discussions of friendship and justice in Aquinas, see Schwartz (2007), chapters 6 and 7, and Roniger (2018).

²⁴ See, e.g., InETH lib.9 l.4.

²⁵ This is a line Aquinas ascribes to Cicero, but which dates back to Sallust's *Catiline's War*, Book XX, pt. 4, and is, in fact, an attribution to Catiline in that work. Regardless, Aquinas quotes it with approval, e.g., at ST IIaIIae q.29 a.3 co. See also, e.g., InROM cap. 12 l.3; ST IIaIIae q.80 a.1 ad 2; SCG lib.3 cap.95 n.5; SCG lib.3 cap. 151 n.3; and InETH lib.9 l.4. For a discussion of conformity of will, see Schwartz (2007), chapters 2 and 3.

²⁶ See, e.g., InROM cap. 12 l.3; ST IIaIIae q.80 a.1 ad 2; QDVir q.4 a.3 co.; and InETH lib.9 l.4. For a brief comparison of Aristotle's account of friendship to Aquinas's that tries to make trouble for the idea that Aquinas successfully incorporates loving another for their own sake into his account, see Fuchs (2013). On addressing those worries, see, e.g., Gallagher (1996) and (1999); Osborne (2005); and Olver (2017).

²⁷ See, e.g., SCG lib.3 cap.151 n.3; InETH lib.9 l.4, l.14; and InIO cap.13 l.7. In this connection, see Schwartz (2007) and his discussion of concord (8ff.).

virtues. Friendship, then, is an excellent, although partial, image of common happiness. It is an image that should help make clearer why aggregating individual happinesses is not enough to secure common happiness. It is obvious that a friendship does not result merely from aggregating two good people, but rather requires that those two people have the right sort of relationship to one another, the right sort of union, realized especially through activities undertaken together. Common happiness is very similar. Indeed, if true friendship lived out in shared activities were to characterize all or very nearly all of the relationships in some relevant community, friendship would not be merely a lovely image of common happiness – true community-wide friendship, lived out in genuinely good, shared, enjoyed activities, *is* common happiness.²⁸ Heaven is the exemplary case of common happiness precisely because one is actively living out one's friendship with God and one's friendship with everyone else in the heavenly community in the best and most enjoyable of all possible shared activities.

The final part of the case for thinking that common happiness is a special sort of common or shared activity comes from analyzing what Aquinas says about the “common good” when he seems to be using that phrase in the common-happiness sense. In particular, as we will see, after securing justice and peace, the common good is only ultimately realized through the community's acting well in concert. That also suggests that common happiness is a special sort of shared activity.

In analyzing the ‘common good’ in the common-happiness sense, the place to begin is by noting that it is not a matter of simply aggregating good individual actors or individual happy people. That the common good or common happiness is more than such an aggregate comes through very clearly when Aquinas says that “the common good of a community and the good of one person taken singly do not differ only with respect to many and few, but with respect to a formal difference, for the character of the common good and a singular good differ in the way that the character of a whole and a part differ.”²⁹ So, again, common happiness does not result from the mere aggregation of isolated happy individuals. There is something more required for common happiness.

²⁸ Agreeing with Roniger (2020), 283, who says that “friendships . . . constitute the common good of the political body.” It should be clear, then, that with, e.g., Irwin (2007), I think that “we are entitled . . . to appeal to Aquinas’ claims about friendship in order to understand his views about fellow-citizens” (615); see chapter 23 for Irwin’s defense of that claim. See also, e.g., Froelich (1993), 611–612.

²⁹ ST IIaIIae q.58 a.7 ad 2.

This something more, as the passage suggests, is connected to our being parts of the whole that is our community – a whole that “is not some one thing absolutely speaking,” like a human being is, of course, but rather a whole that “has only the unity of order.”³⁰ Still, like the good of a human body made up of many different parts, or like the good of any sort of genuine whole, the community’s good requires that the right sorts of relations hold between its various individual parts – that is, between the members of that community.³¹ According to Aquinas, at the most basic level, right relations hold in a community when that community is just – that is, when from the greatest to the least in that community, “each is given their due.”³² Justice in this sense is purely a matter of how a community’s members are treated by others and not at all about, for example, the motives behind that treatment.³³ And justice in this sense is *a* common good, which is absolutely vital for securing *the* common good, namely, common happiness.³⁴

Justice, as it were, puts all of the individual pieces into the right spots. It is the job of another common good to build on and solidify that justice – *a* common good, which is also absolutely vital for securing *the* common good.³⁵ In particular, it is peace (*pax*) that builds on and preserves those right relations in a community, like flesh formed around bones. As Aquinas thinks of it, “peace is an output of justice indirectly, namely, inasmuch as it [i.e., justice] removes that which prohibits it [i.e., peace].”³⁶ Peace itself, as Aquinas thinks of it, is “the unity of the multitude.”³⁷ In a truly united community – that is, a community enjoying peace – there is “nothing that disturbs the right order of the community.”³⁸ Peace, then, is more than the right or just ordering of a community by itself.³⁹ It is also more than an absence of external conflict. As Aquinas thinks of it, in its

³⁰ InETH lib.1 l.1 n.5. For discussions of unity of order, see, e.g., Finnis (1998a), chapter 2; Baur (2012), 238–244; and Kempshall (1999), chapter 3.

³¹ ST IaIIae q.111 a.5 ad 1.

³² SCG lib.3 c.128 n.6. See also ST IaIIae q.57, and then so as to see how this justice-as-getting-what-one-is-due sense is incorporated into a general discussion of justice-as-virtue, see ST IaIIae q.58. For a sustained discussion of Aquinas’s account of justice that also shows how these two senses are related, see Porter (2016b).

³³ See ST IaIIae q.57, esp. a.1 co.

³⁴ This is how I think passages in which justice is called “*commune bonum*” (or its cognates) should be read. See, e.g., ST IaIIae q.19 a.10 co.; ST IaIIae q.96 a.3 co.; and InETH lib.9 l.6 n.10. On this point, I think something similar to Kempshall (1999), e.g., 127.

³⁵ This is how I think passages in which peace is called “*commune bonum*” (or its cognates) should be read – see, e.g., ST IaIIae q.96 a.3 co. and DR lib.1 cap.3.

³⁶ ST IaIIae q.29 a.3 ad 3. See also, e.g., SCG lib.3 cap.128 n.6. ³⁷ DR lib.1 cap.16.

³⁸ InSENT, lib. 4 d. 49 q. 1 a.2 qc.4 co. ³⁹ Kossel (2002), 180, seems to claim otherwise.

true sense, peace requires internal harmony undergirding interpersonal harmony, or a matter of the inner peace of many individuals undergirding mutual loving relationships.⁴⁰ For Aquinas, peace is not a superficial getting along, then, but a really profound sort of connection and unity among individuals. And, more than that, in its true sense, according to Aquinas, peace involves an exacting, deep explanation for the presence of that unity and the absence of things disturbing a community's just order.⁴¹ That explanation ultimately stems from the internal integration and general satisfaction of each individual, on the one hand, and from those individuals sharing relevant goals and desires, on the other.⁴²

On the side of internal integration, the sort of inner peace that undergirds interpersonal peace involves an absence of conflict both between what a person wants *qua* animal and *qua* rational and, more generally, an absence of internal conflict over what should be done or pursued.⁴³ So, for example, a person who both strongly wants to eat a cupcake and strongly doesn't want to eat a cupcake is not at peace. A person who both strongly wants to go to medical school and strongly doesn't want to go to medical school is not at peace. So, according to Aquinas, the internally divided among us do not know true peace.

But even purely inner peace requires more than that, according to Aquinas. An internally integrated person may still lack inner peace, in particular, if that person's well-integrated and well-ordered desires remain unsatisfied. This is so because, by its very nature, peace involves "obtaining what one desires tranquilly and without impediment."⁴⁴ So being unsatisfied in important matters is enough to spoil the inner peace even of an internally integrated person. Note that this second element of inner peace builds on the first. After all, as long as some internal conflict over something important remains, a conflicted person is not truly satisfied no matter which option they pursue – for example, whether our would-be doctor goes to medical school or not; so long as the sharp internal division remains, a part of them will remain unsatisfied.

True peace flows from this sort of internal harmony or inner peace out into the world of relationships. Here, what is most important to peace is possessing certain shared goals and desires. Most fundamentally, true peace involves not merely my wanting the same things that you do, but my

⁴⁰ For a discussion of peace in this sense, see, e.g., Miner (2016). See also Stump (2010), chapters 6 and 7, and her discussion of why internal integration is necessary for deep or strenuous union between persons.

⁴¹ See, e.g., SCG lib.3 cap.117 n.5.

⁴² See, e.g., ST IIaIIae q.29.

⁴³ ST IIaIIae q.29 a.1 co.

⁴⁴ ST IIaIIae q.29 a.2 co.

wanting *you* to get what you want for your own sake in the same way I want *me* to get what I want for my own sake.⁴⁵ For true peace to be enjoyed, it must be the case that “a human being wants to satisfy the will of the neighbor as they do their own.”⁴⁶ This is the sort of “union of one’s own appetite with the appetite of another” that is required for peace in the true sense.⁴⁷ And it is that sort of union of relevant goals and desires, without internal division, that helps a community secure both enduring justice and profound unity.

With justice and peace secured, however, still more is required to attain common happiness, in particular, well-coordinated action in the community.⁴⁸ As Aquinas says, “For the good life of a multitude to be established,” it is just a preliminary step “that the multitude is established in peace.”⁴⁹ The next step is “that the multitude bound together in the unity of peace is directed to acting well.”⁵⁰ Justice and peace alone, then, do not fully capture the nature of the common good or common happiness.⁵¹ Having attained justice and peace (as well as sufficient material goods), a community must also act well in harmony.⁵² This is clear from Aquinas’s comparing peace to “the unity of a human being caused by nature.”⁵³ He goes on with the comparison, saying, “For as a human being cannot do anything well, unless the unity of their parts is presupposed, so too a multitude of human beings lacking the unity of peace, while fighting against itself, is hindered from acting well.”⁵⁴ Now, according to Aquinas, a community’s acting well requires coordination suited to the particular community in question.⁵⁵ As a result, common happiness requires not only justice and peace, but also proper coordination of the various endeavors undertaken in a community.⁵⁶

Crucially, then, realizing the common good or common happiness is ultimately a matter of common action or shared activity. In particular, it is a matter of those bound together in a community acting well in harmony.

⁴⁵ See, e.g., ST IIaIIae q.29 a.3 co. ⁴⁶ ST IIaIIae q.29 a.3 co.

⁴⁷ ST IIaIIae q.29 a.3 co. Love of neighbor in general may involve charity or not (see, e.g., ST IIaIIae q.18 a.2 ad 3).

⁴⁸ In seeing the common good as connected to peace *and* acting well collectively, I agree with Copleston (1962), 135. The need for coordination in achieving the common good is noted, e.g., by Jensen (2015), 161–162.

⁴⁹ DR lib.1 cap.16. ⁵⁰ DR lib.1 cap.16.

⁵¹ DR lib.1 cap.16. Some commentators treat them in this way – see, e.g., Murphy (2005), 148, and esp. Murphy (1997), 336–343.

⁵² DR lib.1 cap.16. ⁵³ DR lib.1 cap.16.

⁵⁴ DR lib.1 cap.16. See also DR lib.1 cap.3 and SCG lib.3 cap.128 n.4.

⁵⁵ See, e.g., ST IaIIae q.96 a.1 co.

⁵⁶ Perhaps by leaving something to the free choices of individuals in that community.

Their acting well in harmony is in part a matter of their acting justly toward one another, in part a matter of their sharing the sorts of goals and desires requisite for true peace, and in part a matter of following a shared plan for coordination suitable to their community. In so acting, they are no mere collection of individuals because they share at least key fundamental aims whenever they act: They want, at a minimum, to protect and promote the happiness of those in the community as well as protect and promote justice, peace, and well-coordinated action in the community. Again, at that level of generality, at least, they are all engaged in the very same shared activity and, in the end, it seems that that shared activity just is the community's common happiness.

There is, then, a strong cumulative case for holding that common happiness is a common or shared activity. In particular, again, it seems there is a strong case for holding that common happiness is constituted by all (or very many) of a community's members engaging in and enjoying genuinely good activities that are consistent with, partially constitutive of, and motivated at some level by the individual happinesses of a community's members as well as justice, peace, and well-coordinated community action. Common happiness so understood has two main deeply inter-related aspects: first, the individual happinesses of those who make up the relevant complete community and, second, the profound sort of justice, peace, and, ultimately, coordinated action that exist among those individuals.⁵⁷

⁵⁷ I take myself to be in basic agreement with Goyette (2013) on what the reference to "the common good" amounts to in Aquinas's definition of law, at least in the case of the political common good. He holds that "the political common good . . . consists in the virtuous life of the political multitude, or what Aquinas calls 'communal happiness'" (134) (cf. Kempshall (1999), chapter 4). We agree entirely that, for Aquinas, the common good is equivalent to common or communal happiness (although Goyette apparently restricts this claim to the context of human law, whereas – as will become clear in Chapter 7 – I think it applies far more broadly). We are in at least rough agreement on how to characterize what communal happiness fundamentally is. I prefer to characterize it, most fundamentally, as a shared activity involving the two interrelated aspects that appear in the text, whereas he characterizes it, most fundamentally, as a matter of living virtuously together. Our two accounts are clearly related. Perhaps my account could be thought of as an attempt to spell out in more detail what exactly it means for a community to live virtuously together in the way necessary for common happiness. However, this view is at odds with other well-known readings. Furthest from my view is Finnis, who holds that the political common good, at least, is limited and instrumental and ultimately ordered to the private good of individuals and families (see, e.g., 1998a, esp. chapter 7, and 1998b). However, I should also note that Finnis's understanding of the common good *qua* fulfillment of all a community's members is relatively close to the way that I understand the reference to the common good in the essence of law (see, e.g., 1998a, 113–117, 238–239). But he is very clear that he does not take the reference to 'common good' in the definition of law to unequivocally refer to the common good *qua* fulfillment (see, e.g., 1998a, 222–239). I think that many of Finnis's critics have decisively shown that, whatever its merits as a

These aspects are very deeply interrelated, as Aquinas thinks of them. For an individual person to be happy in a community, they must stand in just relations to their neighbors (inasmuch as those just relations depend on them), be at peace with their neighbors (inasmuch as that peace depends on them), and be engaged in appropriate coordinated action (inasmuch as that action depends on them). This is so because “the goodness of any part is considered in proportion to its whole . . . Since, therefore, every human being is a part of a community, it is impossible for any human being to be good, unless they are well proportioned to the common good.”⁵⁸ In other words, being a good or virtuous person requires having the right sorts of beliefs and attitudes about the good of the community as a whole, which lead one to act always, at least in part, for the good of one’s whole community.⁵⁹ The central virtue here, which I will discuss in detail in Chapter 8, is what Aquinas calls “general justice.” And since being happy is always a matter of engaging in virtuous activities, animated by one’s virtues (broadly construed), an individual cannot be happy without playing their part well in the community, as an agent of happiness for others as well as an agent of justice, peace, and appropriate coordinated action in their community.

And so, it bears repeating, common happiness is ultimately constituted by all (or very many) of a community’s members engaging in and enjoying genuinely good activities that are consistent with, partially constitutive of, and motivated at some level by the individual happinesses of a community’s members as well as justice, peace, and well-coordinated community action. This is no mere collection of happy individuals because they share at least key fundamental aims whenever they act, including the desire to protect and promote the happiness of those in the community as well as protect and promote justice, peace, and well-coordinated action in the community. At that level of generality, at least, they are all engaged in the

theory, Finnis’s reading as applied to the State fits the texts badly and should be rejected as a reading of Aquinas – see, e.g., Goyette (2013); Dewan (2007), 279–311; and Pakaluk (2001). Authors who emphasize justice and peace come closer to my view. I think here, e.g., of Murphy (1997) and Kossel (2002), 178–179, who also take virtue and friendship to be relevant features of the common good.

⁵⁸ ST IaIIae q.92 a.1 ad 3. See also, e.g., ST IaIIae q.47 a.10 ad 2.

⁵⁹ On this point, see Adams (2004) and Shanley (1999). It is in not giving this point sufficient weight that I think, e.g., Irwin goes wrong by trying to reconcile the community’s good and the individual’s good by appeal to the way in which the individual’s good might be advanced by their caring about the community’s good (see, e.g., 2007, 619–621). Instead, we should recognize that, according to Aquinas, the individual’s good in and of itself requires that one be committed in the first place to furthering the community’s good rather than one’s own good considered in isolation.

very same shared activity, and it is that shared activity which constitutes the community's common happiness.

The most complete or perfect sort of common happiness, like the perfect happiness of an individual, is lofty. And as I noted above, like the perfect happiness of an individual, it is not fully achievable on earth. For those on earth, the most perfect sort of common happiness is an ideal toward which to strive, a target at which to aim. But, just as Aquinas allows for imperfect sorts of individual happiness on earth, Aquinas seems to allow for less perfect sorts of common happiness in this life. This comes through most clearly in Aquinas's reflections on the aspect of common happiness connected to individual happinesses. As we've seen, Aquinas says, "It is impossible for a whole community to be happy unless all or *very many* parts of the community have happiness."⁶⁰ *Perfect* common happiness, we might say, requires that all of a community's members be happy. But, as Aquinas thinks of it, there seems to be a kind of *imperfect* common happiness that might obtain so long as "very many" people in some relevant community are happy. We would, of course, like to hear more about how many people must be happy in order for a community to achieve this sort of imperfect common happiness and why it takes precisely that many, but it should be clear enough that Aquinas is willing to allow that some imperfect kind of common happiness can exist in a community where not every aspect of common happiness is fully realized. It seems likely that Aquinas would be willing to say something similar in the case of the second interrelated aspect of common happiness – in particular, that a very just, peaceful, and well-coordinated community that falls short of perfection in these areas could, in principle, enjoy some measure of an imperfect sort of common happiness. Take peace, in particular, as an example. Perhaps something short of the sort of profound harmony found in a truly peaceful community would be enough to achieve an imperfect sort of common happiness – perhaps Aquinas would allow that some level of common happiness is possible when there is, for example, widespread significant concern for one's compatriots and agreement on important matters pertaining to life together.

Like individual happiness, then, common happiness seems to be binary in one sense and a matter of degree in another. It is binary in the sense that each and every community has either attained common happiness at a given point in time or they have not. There is always a "Yes" or "No" answer to the question, "Has this community attained common

⁶⁰ InPOL lib.2 l.5 n.15 (emphasis added).

happiness?” Although Aquinas is not as clear in the case of common happiness as individual happiness, roughly, the answer is “Yes” when a sufficient number of a community’s members are engaging in and enjoying genuinely good activities that are consistent with, partially constitutive of, and motivated at some level by the individual happinesses of that community’s members as well as justice, peace, and well-coordinated community action. The answer is “No” when an insufficient number of people are engaged in this sort of shared activity. That is the admittedly vague cutoff point below which no community counts as enjoying common happiness. Still, as Aquinas understands it, common happiness seems to come in degrees above that cutoff point. This is so because, for the reasons mentioned above, some communities more fully realize common happiness so understood, for example, by having even more members than are strictly necessary engaged in this shared activity or by their more fully realizing peace in their community.

Reflecting on less than perfect cases may help to clarify the process whereby common happiness could emerge in a given community as individuals strive to attain the lofty goal of perfect or complete common happiness. As Aquinas tells us, “although the common good is more divine, nevertheless the good of one (*bonum singulare*) is prior in the way of generation.”⁶¹ In principle, then, an individual can achieve their own happiness before their community achieves common happiness.⁶² This should come as no surprise, since it is possible for one individual to engage in and enjoy genuinely good activities, even if lots of other people in the community fall short of the virtues that make such activities possible. In this way, as individuals become happy one by one, enough of a community’s members might engage in the relevant kinds of activities imperfect common happiness to emerge. Now, because “it is impossible for any human being to be good, unless they are well proportioned to the common good,” for any particular individual to be happy, they must be doing their part to secure common happiness, not only by seeing to their own happiness but also by acting appropriately in trying to help secure the happinesses of the other members of their community as well as playing their part in securing justice, peace, and well-coordinated action in their community.⁶³ A virtuous circle is possible here, then: Happy individuals strive for common happiness and thereby help to produce other happy individuals who then strive for common happiness and so on.

⁶¹ InSENT lib.4 d.2 q.1 a.3 ad 3.

⁶² Contra, e.g., Copleston (1962), 138.

⁶³ ST IaIIae q.92 a.1 ad 3. See also, e.g., ST IIaIIae q.47 a.10 ad 2.

Still, we certainly should not downplay the role of a community in an individual's becoming happy. If one's community is bad enough, developing the virtues necessary for happiness may be practically impossible, and even if one were to become virtuous, the bad state of one's community would certainly interfere with one's prospects for engaging in and enjoying the very best sorts of activities, at the very least.⁶⁴ Indeed, if things were bad enough – say, for example, that morally obligatory dissent in one's society were met with severe sanctions (as was the case, for example, in Nazi Germany) – acting in accord with virtue may require that one choose to suffer terribly and so be left only with that meager sort of happiness discussed in Chapter 4: the happiness associated with bearing righteous suffering well. Or virtue may even require that one prefer death to acquiescence in evil and thereby lead to the end of one's earthly happiness.⁶⁵ This is, as we'll see in more detail in Chapter 7, one reason a community's laws are extremely important from Aquinas's point of view.

6.3 Common Happiness, Individual Happiness, and the True Ultimate End

With both common happiness and individual happiness in view, we are now in a position to address an important part of Aquinas's account of happiness that I have not discussed thus far, namely, the idea that happiness is the ultimate end of human beings. In this section, I will argue that it is the *common happiness* of heaven that is the true ultimate end of each human being. As a result, the traits associated with the ultimate end that tend to be associated with individual happiness by commentators should be associated with common happiness rather than individual happiness. Perhaps most importantly, it turns out that, properly understood, all intentional human actions are ultimately motivated at some level by a person's desire for *common happiness*. And so, as a part of this section, I establish the first element of Aquinas's Holistic Eudaimonism.

This reading of Aquinas may well be startling to many commentators. Some commentators have pointed in this direction.⁶⁶ However, I know of no one who has claimed that common happiness is the ultimate end of

⁶⁴ On the role of larger social groups in securing happiness, see, e.g., ST IIaIIae q.47 a.10 ad 2.

⁶⁵ Stump (2004) and (2005), 335–337, makes this point vividly. See also, e.g., Bowlin (1999), 200–201. See the Conclusion of this study for more.

⁶⁶ To my knowledge, the closest anyone comes to defending this idea is Olver (2017): “the common good, or the good of the whole, is good of the part . . . As such it is more the end and more the good of the part than the part's private or individual good is” (691). Verner (2023) also comes fairly close.

each human being. Almost universally, commentators treat *individual happiness* as the ultimate end and, thus, as at some level the ultimate motivation behind all intentional human actions. For example, McCluskey says, “Aquinas holds that human beings always act for the sake of an ultimate end, which is happiness.”⁶⁷ There are very good textual grounds for holding as much. For example, Aquinas says, “The will naturally tends to its ultimate end, for every human being naturally wills happiness, and all other volitions are caused by this natural volition, since whatever a human being wills they will on account of the end.”⁶⁸ What is more, there is very little direct textual evidence for the view for which I am advocating, much less than there is for the other two elements of Aquinas’s Holistic Eudaimonism, for example. Still, I think there is good reason to believe that Aquinas is committed to precisely this view. And showing as much is the first step in explaining how Aquinas changes the focus of eudaimonistic ethics from the happiness of the individual to the happiness of the whole community of which the individual is a part.

The basic case, which I defend below, is as follows. Rightly understood, perfect happiness is an individual’s participation in the shared activity of heaven or, in other words, an individual’s participation in the common happiness of the Kingdom of Heaven. It is the individual’s activity *as appropriately shared with others* that has the traits associated with the ultimate end. In particular, it is the *fruitio* of God *as appropriately shared with others* that fully perfects a human being and that ultimately motivates every human actor in heaven. Therefore, common happiness is the true ultimate end of a human being. I will now defend these claims in turn.

In light of the ground covered in Chapter 3 and the above discussion, we are in a position to recognize that perfect happiness is an individual’s participation in the shared activity of heaven, or, in other words, in the common happiness of the Kingdom of Heaven. Most fundamentally, that activity or happiness is shared with God.⁶⁹ Or, rather, it is God, “the source from which happiness flows,” who “shares His happiness with us” in heaven.⁷⁰ God does so because, according to Aquinas, God loves those in heaven “as a friend loves a friend.”⁷¹ That is why God “draws them into

⁶⁷ McCluskey (2000), 79. See also, e.g., MacDonald (1990); Ardagh (1974); Frey (2019a); and Osborne (2008).

⁶⁸ ST Ia q.60 a.2 co. See also, e.g., ST Ia q.82 a.1 and ST IIaIIae q.1.

⁶⁹ For the fundamentality claim, see, e.g., ST IIaIIae q.4 a.8 ad 3.

⁷⁰ First quote: ST IIaIIae q.25 a.12 co. Second quote: ST IIaIIae q.23 a.1 co. See also, e.g., ST IIaIIae q.26 a.3 co.

⁷¹ InSENT lib.2 d.26 a.1 ad 2.

the community of His own *fruitio*,” so they might share the greatest possible activity, the greatest possible happiness, with the greatest possible Friend.⁷² When a person in heaven peers into God’s essence and enjoys it to the limit, they are aware of themselves as joining in with God in God’s own *fruitio* of God’s self.⁷³ They are aware that they are joining their Friend in what that Friend is doing. As a result, God and those in heaven are engaged in an intimate shared activity, involving personal connection, mutual awareness, and a shared focus ultimately on God in God’s essence.⁷⁴ Being perfectly happy is a matter of participating in that shared activity with God, a matter of participating in the common happiness of heaven or, in other words, a matter of taking part in that appropriately shared, enjoyed, genuinely good activity.

It is important to notice that, even if God were alone in heaven with one human being, perfect happiness would still be the individual’s participation in the common happiness of heaven. After all, entirely on their own, God and that one other individual would enjoy common happiness together.⁷⁵ In such a case, both would get what they are due (insofar as human beings can give God what God is due). They would both be internally integrated. They would both be entirely content with what they have. They would both love the other for their own sake. And they would both be engaged in a shared, perfectly coordinated activity whereby they are perfectly happy as individuals.

Indeed, even if God were entirely alone in heaven, all the same perfect happiness would be, as it were, the individual’s participation in the common happiness of heaven. For Aquinas thinks that “Divine Happiness is shared by the Three Persons” of the Trinity.⁷⁶ And it seems that God in God’s Triune nature most perfectly exemplifies what it is for persons to share an activity in a just, peaceful, and well-coordinated way.⁷⁷ In the end, then, stemming from the social nature of the Triune God that is written into our nature as images of God, an image that is then elevated

⁷² InSENT lib.2 d.26 a.1 ad 2.

⁷³ Aquinas holds God is happy in God’s essence. See, e.g., ST IIaIIae q.3 a.1 ad 1. Cf. ST Ia q.26.

⁷⁴ On shared attention and Aquinas, see, e.g., Stump (2010), esp. chapter 6, and Pinsent (2012b). On the importance of this personal connection to perfect happiness in Aquinas, see Stump (2022), esp. chapter 5.

⁷⁵ Cf. ST IIaIIae q.4 a.8 ad 3.

⁷⁶ InSENT lib.4 d.4 q.1 a.4 qc.4 s.c.1. Cf. InSENT lib.3 d.19 q.1 a.5 qc.3 ad 2.

⁷⁷ That God *is* an activity in a sense, see, e.g., ST IIaIIae q.5 a.2 ad 3 and ST Ia q.3 a.2. For God’s justice, see, e.g., ST Ia q.21. God in God’s self clearly exemplifies what Aquinas understands by peace – see, e.g., ST IIaIIae q.29. For God’s coordination of activity among the persons, see, e.g., ST Ia q.43.

by our participation in God's nature through grace, the nature of God's happiness as a common or shared activity is written into the nature of our happiness.⁷⁸

Since sharing in God's activity is what is essential, what has been said is enough to show that perfect happiness is an individual's participation in the shared activity of heaven or, in other words, in the common happiness of the Kingdom of Heaven. But we should note, once again, that Aquinas believes that the activity of heaven is also shared with other people, other heavenly friends. Indeed, each person is engaged in an activity shared with everyone else in heaven in a robust sense that involves mutual awareness, mutual love, and a shared focus on God. That is why, for example, those in heaven enjoy one another's *fruitio* of God.⁷⁹ In the end, that shared activity is a matter of every member of the heavenly community maximally enjoying the very best possible activity together and their doing so in a manner consistent with and partially constitutive of that community's being a just, peaceful, and well-coordinated place. In other words, that shared activity is the best possible variety of common happiness.

Before showing that it is the individual's activity *as appropriately shared with others* that has the traits associated with the ultimate end, it is important to get clearer on the traits that Aquinas associates with the ultimate end. With the term 'ultimate end,' Aquinas picks out three related things.⁸⁰ First, there is the *ratio*, or nature, of the ultimate end, which is "to be fulfilled in one's perfection."⁸¹ In other words, by its very nature, a thing's attaining its ultimate end is a matter of its being fully perfected as a member of its kind, whether the thing in question is, for example, a maple tree, a fox, or a human being.

The other two pertinent things Aquinas picks out with the term 'ultimate end' concern what it is that fully perfects things. As Aquinas sees it, in one sense, what perfects every particular thing is God, and so there is a sense in which God is the ultimate end of all things. In particular, God is the ultimate end of all things in the sense that God is, as it were, the object or thing out there in the world toward which all things strive so as to be perfected because God is "the very thing in which the nature (*ratio*) of the good is found."⁸² So, "if we are talking about the ultimate end of human beings as the very thing which is the end, everything else has the same

⁷⁸ That Aquinas takes God's nature as a Trinity to be written into the image of God in human beings, see, e.g., ST Ia q.93 a.5. On the sociality of God's Triune nature and its relation to our own nature, see, e.g., Stump (2022), esp. chapter 5.

⁷⁹ QDVir q.2 a.4 ad 2.

⁸⁰ For more, see Stenberg (2016b).

⁸¹ ST IaIIae q.1 a.7 co.

⁸² ST IaIIae q.1 a.8 co.

ultimate end as human beings because God is the ultimate end of human beings and of all other things.”⁸³

In another sense, what perfects everything is attaining to God in some particular manner that is appropriate to things of one’s kind. And so, unsurprisingly, there is a sense in which the ultimate end of each thing is to attain God in the particular manner appropriate to things of its kind. In this connection, Aquinas says,

If we are talking about the ultimate end of human beings as to the attainment of the end, non-rational creatures do not share in this end of human beings. For human beings and other rational creatures attain the ultimate end by knowing and loving God, which is not possible for other creatures. Other creatures attain the ultimate end insofar as they take part in some likeness of God inasmuch as they exist or are alive or also think.⁸⁴

It is ‘the ultimate end’ understood as *the attainment of the end* that is relevant in thinking about the sense in which happiness is the ultimate end of human beings. That is clear, for example, because Aquinas tells us that “happiness is called the ultimate end in the way that the attainment of an end is called an end.”⁸⁵

The ultimate end, so understood, plays a fundamental role in Aquinas’s moral psychology. According to Aquinas, “everything that a human being desires they desire for the sake of the ultimate end.”⁸⁶ Most fundamentally, Aquinas thinks this is the case because everything a person desires is desired in one way or another as “ordered to complete perfection.”⁸⁷ And it is the ultimate end understood as the attainment of the end that involves the complete perfection of a thing. As a result, according to Aquinas, on some level happiness is the ultimate motivation behind all intentional human actions.

I will now argue that the true ultimate end of each human being is the *fruitio* of God as *appropriately shared* with God (and other people). In other words, I will argue that the true ultimate end is the common happiness of heaven. First, I will show that, according to Aquinas, it is the activity of heaven as *appropriately shared with others* that fully perfects a human being.⁸⁸ Second, I will show that, according to Aquinas, it is the activity of heaven as *appropriately shared with others* that ultimately motivates every human actor in heaven.

⁸³ ST IaIIae q.1 a.8 co. For stress on God as ultimate end, see, e.g., Shields (2014)

⁸⁴ ST IaIIae q.1 a.8 co. ⁸⁵ ST IaIIae q.3 a.1 ad 3. ⁸⁶ ST IaIIae q.1 a.6 co.

⁸⁷ ST IaIIae q.1 a.6 co.

⁸⁸ Stump has argued in a similar vein that human nature and thus human perfection must be understood as relational (see especially 2022, chapter 5).

Aquinas takes our social nature very seriously. As we have seen repeatedly, he thinks that human beings are parts in greater wholes that have the unity of order, culminating in the whole that is a complete community, whether a political community or the Kingdom of Heaven. In thinking about the perfection of a part with a place in a greater whole, Aquinas holds that “a part is not perfect except in the whole.”⁸⁹ This is true not only of substantial wholes but also of, as it were, natural wholes with the unity of order, such as a complete community.⁹⁰ Indeed, Aquinas explains that what underlies the fact that “particular human beings expose themselves to death for the preservation of a community of which they are a part” is that “every part is imperfect in itself, but has its perfection in its whole.”⁹¹ So, entirely generally, a human being can only be fully perfected as a part of the greater whole that is their community.

However, of course, simply being a part of the greater whole that is a complete community is not sufficient for being fully perfected. In order for a part to be fully perfected, it must play its proper role in the whole perfectly. This is so, fundamentally, because “the goodness of any part is considered in proportion to its whole . . . Since, therefore, every human being is a part of a community, it is impossible for any human being to be good, unless they are well proportioned to the common good.”⁹² Because of the relationship that Aquinas thinks holds between goodness and perfection, noted in Chapter 1, Aquinas is equally committed to holding that it is impossible for any human to be *fully perfected* unless they are well-proportioned to the common good. In the context of heaven, being well-proportioned to the common good is a matter of appropriately sharing the *fruitio* of God with others. In particular, it is a matter of treating others justly, being at peace with others, and engaging in the well-coordinated shared activity that is the *fruitio* of God. Everyone in heaven is, in fact, well-proportioned to the common good in this sense. Their commitment to justice is even greater than their commitment to their own happiness. This is so because every member of the heavenly community “desires that which is more fitting with respect to God than that which would be better for themselves, and so they desire to preserve divine justice in the very fact that they have less [happiness than other people].”⁹³ As we have seen, they

⁸⁹ InDN cap.4 l.9 n.406.

⁹⁰ See, e.g., Olver (2017). There are still important differences between substances and things with the unity of order (see, e.g., Finnis (1998a), chapter 2).

⁹¹ InSENT lib.3 d.29 q.1 a.3 co. See also, e.g., ST IaIIae q.90 a.2 co.

⁹² ST IaIIae q.92 a.1 ad 3. See also, e.g., ST IIaIIae q.47 a.10 ad 2 and ST IIaIIae q.26 a.3 ad 2.

⁹³ InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.1 a.4 qc.2 ad 3. See also, e.g., QDVir q.2 a.2 co. and ST IIaIIae q.26 a.3 co.

are fully at peace with one another because everyone is internally integrated, everyone is entirely content with what they have, everyone loves the other as themselves and so rejoices in the good of the other as in their own good. And they are engaged in a well-coordinated activity, not only at the level of their fundamental aims but also at the level of what they're actually doing, namely, sharing together in the *fruitio* of God. And so it is the activity of heaven *as appropriately shared with others* that fully perfects a human being as a parts of the whole that is the complete community of the Kingdom of Heaven.

As a result, it makes good sense that the *fruitio* of God *as appropriately shared with others* ultimately motivates every human actor in heaven. In other words, it makes good sense that common happiness ultimately motivates every human actor in heaven. After all, as we have seen, Aquinas thinks that human beings are ultimately motivated at some level by the ultimate end in the attainment of the end sense, which is a matter of the complete perfection of the individual. It was just shown that the complete perfection of the individual is a matter of *appropriately sharing* the *fruitio* of God with God (and others). So the ultimate end, in that sense, is a matter of *appropriately sharing* the *fruitio* of God with God (and others). Appropriately sharing the *fruitio* of God with God and others, rightly understood, is the same thing as the common happiness of heaven. Therefore, the ultimate end is the common happiness of heaven. The ultimate end ultimately motivates those in heaven not only understood in the abstract but also as understood in its true nature. Therefore, the common happiness of heaven understood in its true nature ultimately motivates those in heaven.

This line of argument garners further support from Aquinas's descriptions of the motivational structure of good and virtuous people both on earth and in heaven. It is clear that he thinks that, from their point of view, their most fundamental aim or ultimate end is not their own happiness but the common good or common happiness of the whole community. He says, for example, that "a human being's will is not right when they will some particular good, unless they refer it to the common good as end, since even the natural appetite of every part is ordered to the common good of the whole."⁹⁴ Good people, then, treat the common good of the community as a more fundamental aim than any particular good they may desire for themselves, including their own happiness. Indeed, as we have seen, Aquinas makes this explicit in the case of heaven. He holds that every

⁹⁴ ST IaIIae q.19 a.10 co.

member of the heavenly community desires justice more than a greater share of happiness for themselves. This demonstrates that everyone in the heavenly community recognizes that common happiness, which requires the preservation of justice, is a better, more desirable, and more fundamental end than their own individual happiness.⁹⁵ Their own individual happiness is not their ultimate end. Interestingly, this is not unique to heaven. According to Aquinas, virtuous people love the political community more than themselves, and so, at least when necessary, they “neglect their own personal good” in pursuit of the common good.⁹⁶ Indeed, he says, “It is natural for any part, in its own way, to love the whole more than itself. Thus, both in keeping with this natural inclination and in keeping with political virtue, a good citizen exposes himself to mortal danger for the common good.”⁹⁷ Good and virtuous people, then, recognize that the common good of their community, its common happiness, is their true ultimate end, not their own individual happiness. So it seems clear that, according to Aquinas, it is the common happiness of heaven that ultimately motivates every human actor in heaven.

Perhaps it is worth saying that these good and virtuous people are not deceiving themselves into thinking this in order to attain their own individual happiness. Aquinas is very clear that people in heaven have no false beliefs.⁹⁸ If people in heaven believe that the common happiness of heaven should be their most fundamental aim, their true ultimate end, then it really is their true ultimate end.

Still, I could imagine someone thinking that something must have gone wrong here. After all, one might think, there’s no way that a shared activity *as shared* or common happiness *as common* could be *my* ultimate end as an individual. Strictly speaking, those things can only be the end of the *whole heavenly community*, not each individual in that community. The only real candidates for *my* ultimate end, one might think, are *my* activity and *my* individual happiness taken on their own.

This objection is misguided. Recall that, for Aquinas, a good of a thing is also an end of that thing.⁹⁹ As Aquinas thinks about parts and wholes, a good of the whole is also a good of what is a part of it.¹⁰⁰ In the case at

⁹⁵ Cf. ST Ia q.63 a.1 ad 4: The bad angels failed to desire justice more than their own individual good.

⁹⁶ QDVir q.2 a.2 co.

⁹⁷ QQI q.4 a.3 co. See also, e.g., InSENT lib.3 d.29 a.3 co.; ST IIaIIae q.26 a.3 co.; and InDN cap.4 l.9 n.406.

⁹⁸ See, e.g., ST IIaIIae q.5 a.4 co.

⁹⁹ On goods as ends, see, e.g., QDV q.21 a.1. Cf. InETH lib.1 l.9 n.3.

¹⁰⁰ See, e.g., InDN cap.4 l.9 n.406. On this idea, see, e.g., Olver (2017). See also, e.g., De Koninck (1943) and (2009) and Osborne (2005), chapter 3.

hand, this means that the common good of my political community is *my* good and the common good of the Kingdom of Heaven is *each individual's* good in heaven. Here, I agree with De Koninck, who has argued that, for Aquinas, “the common good is a good which is the good of particulars, not the good of the collectivity envisaged as a sort of singular.”¹⁰¹ This makes good sense, given that Aquinas holds that “the proper good of a human being must be taken in different ways in keeping with the different ways a human being is taken. For the proper good of a human being as a human being is the good of reason” and “one’s good as political is the common good of the community.”¹⁰² The common good of one’s community, then, is a proper good of each individual human being, whether one is a citizen of an earthly political community or “a citizen and member of that happy society, which is called the heavenly Jerusalem.”¹⁰³ So one end that *each individual* has is the common good of the community of which they are a part. It makes good sense, then, that “the common good is called a common end.”¹⁰⁴ Now, what the above arguments show is that the common or shared end that is the common happiness of the Kingdom of Heaven is a better, more desirable, and more fundamental end for those in heaven than their own individual happiness. So it is possible for a shared activity as shared or common happiness as common to be *my* ultimate end. And, indeed, I have shown that Aquinas is committed to precisely this view.

It is worth noting that, on the view that I have laid out, it still makes good sense that, throughout his corpus, Aquinas treats perfect happiness as the ultimate end of each individual human being.¹⁰⁵ After all, on this view it is precisely in attaining perfect happiness that the individual attains their ultimate end. It is just that, when we dig deeper into Aquinas’s explanation as to *why* this is so, the perfect happiness of an individual turns out to be the individual’s participation in the common happiness of heaven, and it is that common happiness in which they thereby participate that is the true ultimate end of each individual.

If this novel reading is correct, it will open up new possibilities as we think through Aquinas’s philosophical commitments. For example, take

¹⁰¹ De Koninck (2009), 75.

¹⁰² QDVir q.2 a.2 co. See also, e.g., QDVir q.1 a.9 co. Cf. InETH lib.1 l.9 n.10.

¹⁰³ QDVir q.2 a.2 co. See also, e.g., QDVir q.1 a.9 co. Cf. InETH lib.1 l.9 n.10.

¹⁰⁴ ST IaIIae q.90 a.2 ad 2. Cf. ST IaIIae q.21 a.2 ad 2.

¹⁰⁵ See, e.g., InSENT lib.4 d.49 q.1 a.1 qc.2 co.; ST IaIIae q.2 a.1 co.; and, indeed, the whole of ST IaIIae q.1–5.

the ongoing debate over whether Aquinas is a kind of egoist.¹⁰⁶ The charge of egoism is easy to understand. As we have seen, on the standard reading, all intentional human actions are ultimately motivated at some level by a person's desire for their own happiness. On that picture, it seems that no matter how altruistic a person's desires may *appear*, they must ultimately be motivated by the person's desire for their own happiness. If that is right, then, according to Aquinas, self-interest is the only ultimate source of motivation. And that is a form of psychological egoism.¹⁰⁷

Subtle and, to my mind, quite persuasive answers to this charge have been written.¹⁰⁸ I think the best of them focus on the idea that we are parts of the greater whole that is our complete community and the idea that the common good of that community is a good of ours.¹⁰⁹ Still, if we take those ideas seriously, the view that I have outlined will not seem so startling. Indeed, although he does not argue that the common happiness of heaven is our true ultimate end, Verner has argued that "common beatitude" plays an important role in addressing the charge of egoism.¹¹⁰ And Olver comes close to the view I have suggested, when he concludes, "Love of others and love of God above self become possible when we take as our ultimate end a common good that perfects us through participation in it."¹¹¹ I have argued for precisely the view that our ultimate end in the attainment sense is a common good that perfects us through participation in it; in particular, our true ultimate end in this sense is the common happiness of heaven, the appropriately shared *fruitio* of God, that perfects us through participation in it.

Now, if the argument of this section holds, there is a very direct way to address the charge of egoism. If all intentional human actions are ultimately motivated at some level by a person's desire for the *common happiness*

¹⁰⁶ For the egoist debate, see, e.g., Dewan (2007), 99–116; Dewart (1966), 30–33; Finnis (1998a), 111–117; Frey (2019b); Gallagher (1996) and (1999); Geiger (1952); Hare (2001), (2013), (2015), (2016), and (2019); Langan (1991); Leonhardt (1998); MacDonald (1990); Nygren (1953), 641–645; Olver (2017); Osborne (2005), chapter 3; Pinckaers (1963a) and (1963b); Porter (2016b), esp. 104–113, 238–256; Porter (2013), (2014), and (2019b); Reiner (1963); Rousselot (1908); Santurri (1991); Shields (2016) and (2017); Toner (2006) and (2007); Verner (2023); and Wohlman (1981).

¹⁰⁷ Recently, this charge has been advanced most forcefully by John Hare, who objects to eudaimonism generally (at least as the term is defined by Kant) – see Hare (2001), (2013), (2015), (2016), and (2019). See also, e.g., Nygren (1953), 641–645, and Dewart (1966), 30–33.

¹⁰⁸ One common and plausible approach focuses on the idea that Aquinas believes that the sense of our self can and should expand to include others, and this sort of self-transcendence is inconsistent with egoism properly understood.

¹⁰⁹ See, for example, Gallagher (1996) and (1999); Osborne (2005); and esp. Olver (2017).

¹¹⁰ Verner (2023). ¹¹¹ Olver (2017), 694.

of the community, then there is no great mystery as to how it might be possible for one person to truly love another person for their own sake without ultimately being motivated by a desire for their own happiness. After all, a part of what it is to desire common happiness is to desire other people's individual good for their own sake. Indeed, on this view, a virtuous person at least is ultimately motivated to desire their own individual good for precisely the same basic underlying reason.

6.4 Conclusion

In this chapter, I have argued that, according to Aquinas, common happiness involves two deeply interrelated aspects: the individual happinesses of those who make up the relevant complete community and the profound sort of justice, peace, and well-coordinated action that exists among those individuals in that relevant community. Ultimately, common happiness is constituted by all (or very many) of a community's members engaging in and enjoying genuinely good activities that are consistent with, partially constitutive of, and motivated at some level by the individual happinesses of a community's members, justice, peace, and well-coordinated community action. Common happiness so understood is a common or shared activity that is genuinely good and enjoyed.

As we have only begun to see, common happiness so understood is of crucial importance in Aquinas's ethics. It is important, first, because – as I have argued – Aquinas is committed to the idea that the common happiness of heaven is the true ultimate end of each human being. By treating common happiness as the true ultimate end of each individual, Aquinas takes a first step in shifting the focus of eudaimonistic ethics from the individual to the community. This is the first element of his Holistic Eudaimonism.

It becomes clearer just how crucial this is to Aquinas's ethics when we keep in mind that Aquinas holds that, in ethics, "it is necessary to grasp the natures of those things ordered to an end from the end."¹¹² As a result, we can only fully understand the true nature of things like moral rules, virtues, and grace by thinking about them in relation to our true ultimate end, *common happiness*. Chapters 7 and 8 will add further support to this contention because there I will show that Aquinas, in fact, does treat common happiness as the ultimate end of, for example, moral rules and virtues. In so doing, I will also show that there are important aspects of the

¹¹² ST IaIIae q.1 pro.

standard interpretation of Aquinas that need to be revised because Aquinas, in fact, puts common happiness at the core of his eudaimonism. In particular, I will argue that, crucially, a person's moral obligations are fundamentally determined by facts about which norms must be followed in order to realize *common happiness*, not individual happiness. And a character trait is a virtue of character fundamentally because it enables a person to play their part in realizing the *common happiness* of their community, not the happiness of the individual whose virtue it is. I will have then established the whole of his Holistic Eudaimonism.